CHAPTER 1

THE DAY AFTER

14 July 2024, 8:32am

It's the first morning in 21 years I am waking up not as a Test cricketer. The first time as an adult I am opening my eyes as someone else, a person undiscovered, a purpose unknown, a future unwritten. The last thing I remember from my final day as an England international is the sun coming up while sitting in a chicken shop at 5:30am. Joe Root had held my gaze in the dressing room after play and said, 'I'm doing whatever you're doing tonight.' There was excuse after excuse to keep the evening going, to stay teammates until the new dawn forced it over. Cricket is good like that. It sticks people together in irreversible ways, even when it can no longer hold you in the same team any more. We drank in the dressing room, waving to the crowds stretched out of the outfield at Lord's. We played cricket again with our children when the crowds left. We returned to the hotel bar where my family and friends had kept the celebrations going. Still not content, we found a bar in Chelsea. Hungry and stretching the night out, we found a chicken shop.

They wouldn't let us in at first. Joe had to take them aside and explain the situation; that there needed to be an end that fitted all the road we had travelled, all the suffering and joys and endless brutal cricket, and hot wings here and now in this establishment was the only acceptable ending. I squinted at him during his negotiation with the staff, where he looked like he was borderline pleading as if it was some kind of dying wish of mine, imagining him to be saying that a table is all we need to make this 41-year-old fast bowler happy after decades of service. After some negotiation, they looked back up at him and over at me and, like some sort of death row